be there to support, protect, nurture and care for each other. It's amazing that someone from outside can sense what we all do.'

Playing against Ireland in Canberra, Hashim and Faf both scored outstanding centuries as we passed 400 for the second match in a row, and then closed out a clinical and efficient victory.

However, just as the experts were starting to talk up our chances, we flew back to New Zealand and produced a really poor performance against Pakistan in Auckland. I sensed something was missing in the warm-up, and we simply did not present on the day. Our bowling was decent in dismissing a motivated Pakistan side for 222 but, inexplicably, our batting lacked any sense of urgency and fight, and we fell 29 runs short.

I managed to score 77 from 58 balls before being the ninth man out, and then attended the post-match media conference and completely failed to conceal my feelings of complete dismay.

'I hate losing,' I told the journalists. 'I really do, so I have nothing good to say about the team at the moment. I'm very disappointed. Even though I scored some runs, I'm still disappointed in my own performance. I should have finished it off. I have done it before so many times and I just couldn't cross the line tonight. We have an opportunity to fix things against the UAE, to play a really good game of cricket and to go into the quarterfinals with a fresh mindset, that mindset of believing we are the best team here. I still believe that, but I just have nothing good to say about our performance today.'

Maybe I was too honest and maybe I was too negative, but I was annoyed by the defeat and, when dealing with the media, I have always found it difficult to be clever and artful, to conceal anything or pretend anything. When they ask a question, they get a straightforward answer.

I was even more blunt in the private team meeting that followed.

'Come on, guys, we can't talk about Protea fire and play like that,' I said. 'It's totally unacceptable, and it's not what we are about as a team. Too many of us were basically fooling around.'